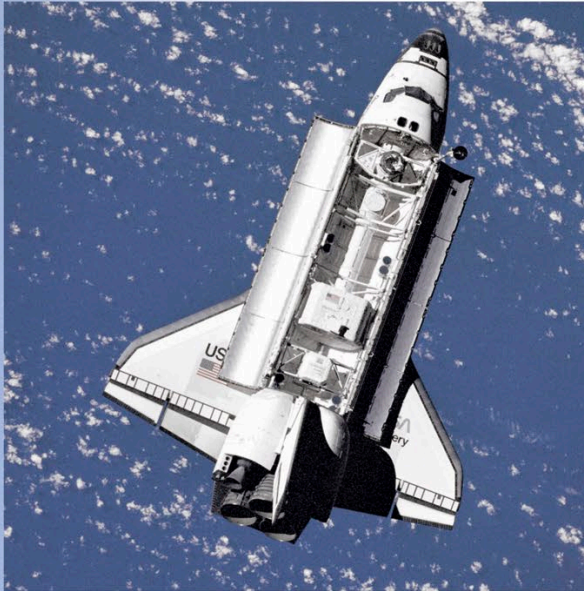




Pop it in there!

Each orbiter had a huge payload bay. You could park a school bus in this cavity, which held the satellites, experiments, and laboratories that needed to be taken into space.

The payload's doors opened once the shuttle was in orbit.



Space shuttle *Endeavour* landing at Edwards Air Force Base, California, USA.

The future explorer

NASA tested a new orbiter, called the *Orion Multipurpose Crew Vehicle*, on 5 December 2014. It is designed to carry six astronauts on each mission, the first of which is planned for the 2020s. This will make it possible for humans to explore asteroids and Mars.



The *Orion Multipurpose Crew Vehicle*

The orbiter fleet

Five orbiters were built. Two have been lost in tragic accidents.



Columbia first flew in 1981. It disintegrated on re-entry in 2003.



Challenger was destroyed in 1986, just 73 seconds after launch.



Discovery first flew in 1984. It marked the 100th shuttle mission in 2000.



Atlantis first flew in 1985. It completed 33 missions, the last one in 2011.



Endeavour replaced *Challenger*. It flew 25 missions between 1992 and 2011.

A safe landing

Shuttles glided down, belly first. Once the orbiter touched the runway, it released a 12-m (40-ft) drag chute to slow it down.